is a sin, because it is a transgression of the rule.' Alberuni despises social institutions that cannot 'be broken through by the special merits of any individual', and yet such institutions, he says, abound among the Hindus. 'We Muslims,' he writes, 'of course, stand entirely on the other side of the question, considering all men as equal, except in piety; and this is the greatest obstacle which prevents any approach or understanding between Hindus and Muslims.'

Alberuni notices the Hindu penchant for classifying things and making all kinds of random lists, like dividing all living beings into three classes and fourteen species. Declaring the number of hells to be 88,000. In the Hindu 'enumeration of things there is much that is arbitrary,' he writes. 'They use or invent numbers of names, and who is to hinder or to control them?'

He notes that in their schools, children use black tablets on which they write 'with a white material from the left to the right'. Adults write letters and books on the bark of the tuz tree after oiling and polishing it. 'The whole book is wrapped up in a piece of cloth and fastened between two tablets of the same size. Such a book is called puthi (cf. pusta, pustaka).' For the Sanskrit texts he reads, he observes that 'Indian scribes are careless, and do not take pains to produce correct and well-collated copies', due to which an author's work often becomes incomprehensible over time. He describes many of their board games too. At times, he resorts to stories to make his point. One such goes as follows: 'Once a sage was asked why scholars always flock to the doors of the rich, whilst the rich are not inclined to call at the doors of scholars. "The scholars," he answered, "are well aware of the use of money, but the rich are ignorant of the nobility of science."'

Farmers and herders pay an unspecified land use tax to the king. Then they pay one-sixth of their income in taxes to the king for protecting their 'property, and their families. The same obligation rests also on the common people, but they will always lie and cheat in the declarations about their property'. Trading businesses, too, pay tax to the state. 'Only the Brahmins are exempt from all these taxes.' Alberuni's account makes it clear that as usual, the Brahmins had a pretty sweet deal. Even the law of the land treated them leniently. They literally got away with murder, asked only to atone for the crime by 'fasting, prayers, and almsgiving'. Members of other